

What Counts as Evidence? Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Cross-AOK • 35-45 min

Category	Cross-AOK	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	what-counts-as-evidence

Big idea: AOKs use different standards of evidence.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Claims from mathematics, art, history, science, and ethics sorted by evidence type. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A card set with proof, testimony, data, interpretation, and expert judgement. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
What Counts as Evidence? Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A comparison of what each AOK accepts and rejects as evidence. Name the AOK, the method being used, and the standard of evidence you would apply.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — AOKs use different standards of evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from What Counts as Evidence? Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Does evidence mean the same thing in every AOK?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Claims from mathematics, art, history, science, and ethics sorted by evidence type.
- A card set with proof, testimony, data, interpretation, and expert judgement.
- A comparison of what each AOK accepts and rejects as evidence.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Cross-AOK.

Activity Steps

1. Assign each group an AOK: mathematics, natural sciences, human sciences, history or arts.
2. Each group decides what evidence would support the claim in that AOK.
3. Groups present their evidence standard.
4. The class discusses whether the same claim means the same thing in every AOK.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Does evidence mean the same thing in every AOK?
- Are some AOKs more reliable, or just differently reliable?
- Can different AOKs answer the same question validly but differently?

Knowledge Questions

- Does evidence mean the same thing in every AOK?
- Are some AOKs more reliable, or just differently reliable?
- Can different AOKs answer the same question validly but differently?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with claims from mathematics, art, history, science, and ethics sorted by evidence type. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...